QUADRANT · SCATTER · THE SHARED LABEL KERNEL

Which dot is this name?

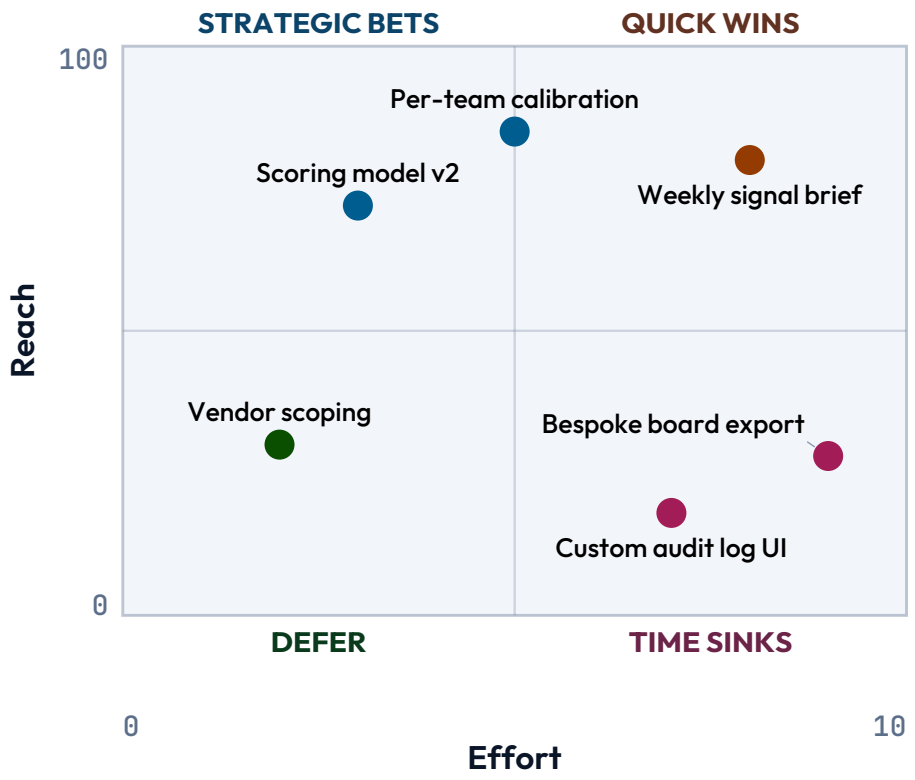
A crowded plot asks the reader two questions. **Which mark does this name belong to**, and **in what order do these names go?** The label kernel now answers both — a hairline from a name that had to travel, and a column that never reads against the dots it labels.

Beside is not the same as nearest.

`placeLabels` has always kept a name **beside its own mark**. On a crowded plot that stops being enough: measured on the stress slide two pages on, six of fourteen names sat closer to another initiative's dot than to their own. A quadrant carries no leader lines, no value pills and no axis to read a position off — proximity was the only channel it had, and it gave the wrong answer six times.

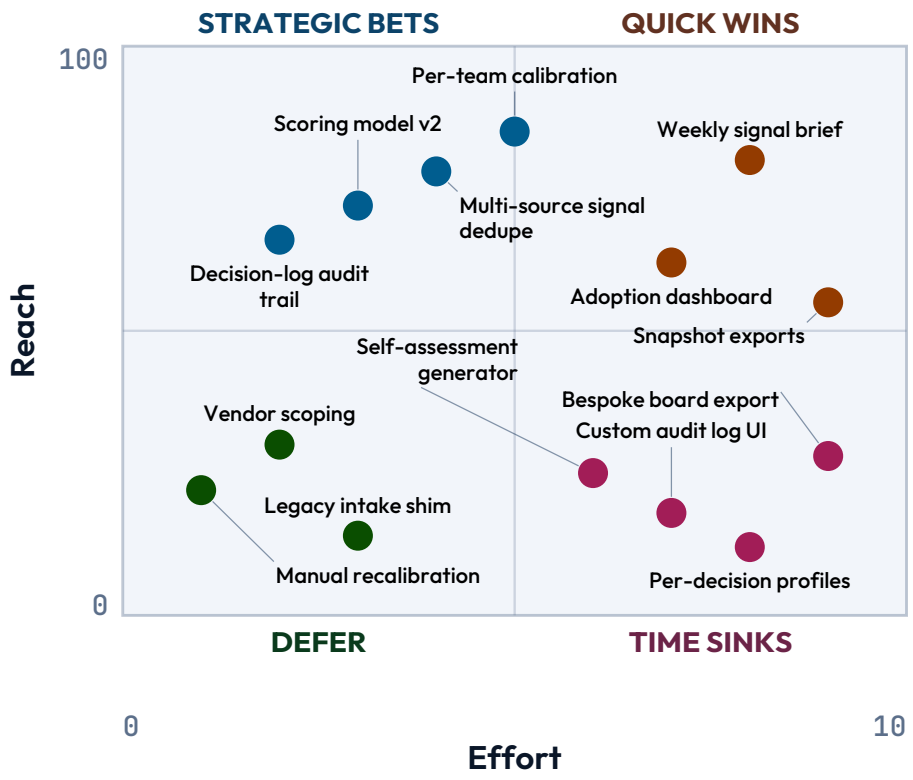
Six initiatives, and not a hairline in sight.

A leader is drawn only where a name could not sit against its own dot. None had to here, so the chart carries none.



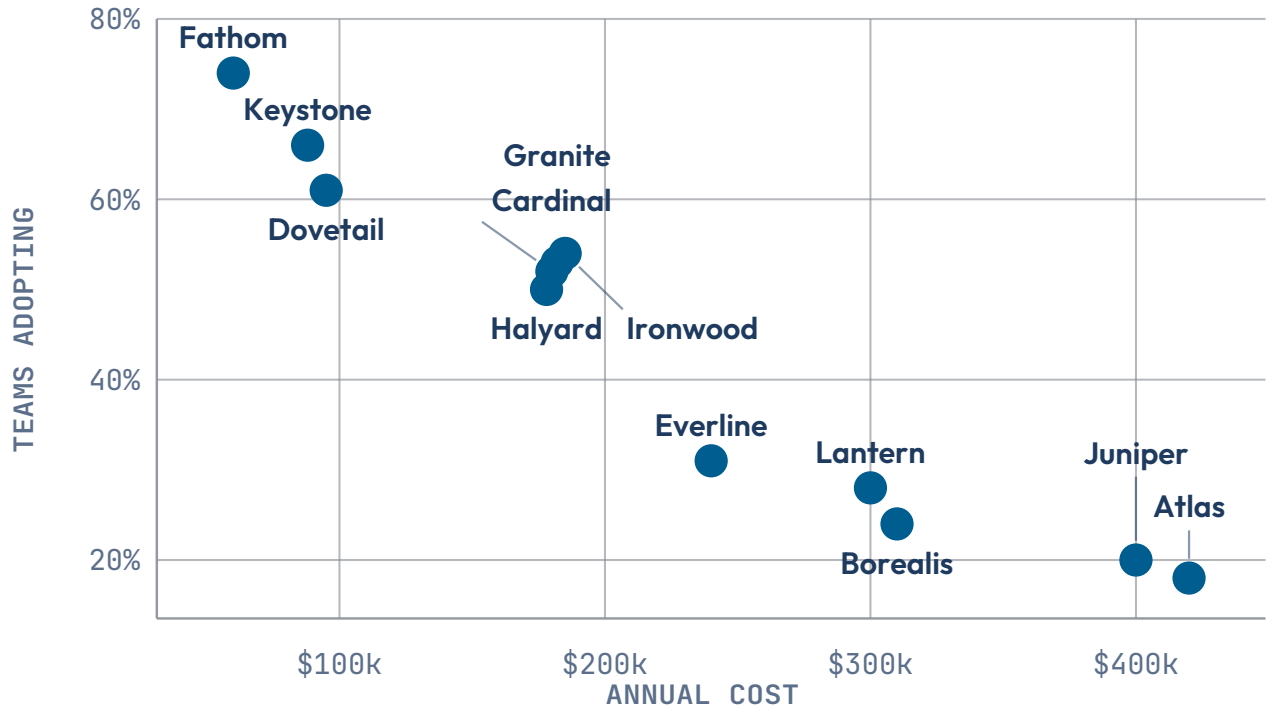
The same chart at the density that broke it.

Eight names travelled far enough to need a line. Trace any one and it lands on its own dot.



Twelve tools, and a cluster the eye cannot separate.

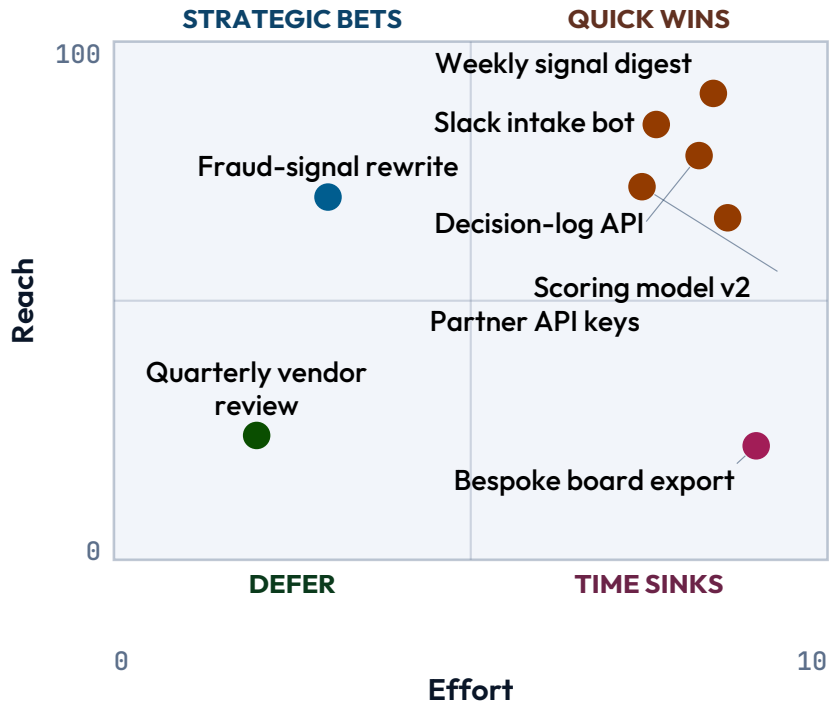
Four sit within four points of each other and their dots overlap. The stacked names read in the dots' order; Ironwood, which could not join that column honestly, moved beside it.



The column reads in the dots’ own order

Order is worth an anchor. It is never worth a name.

Five names in one corner, and their dots far enough apart to check the reading. An out-of-order position is still a clear one, so its cost rides the anchor preference and never the collision test.



A column you can check against the dots

One emitter, one hairline, one rule.

The leader lives in the shared label kernel and both charts draw the same mark from it — quieter than the type, springing from the mark's rim, stopping short of the box, and never drawn through a neighbor's name. The order preference lives beside it, priced in the same currency as the eight anchor positions: enough to buy the whole vertical family before it gives up on the order, and not enough to buy a name set sideways.